SF Symbols

SF Symbols provides thousands of consistent, highly configurable symbols that integrate seamlessly with San Francisco font. Symbols perform well, automatically aligning with text in all weights and sizes.

You can use a symbol to convey an object or concept wherever interface icons can appear, such as in toolbars, tab bars, lists, menus, and settings.

Apple ships with hundreds of symbols and features varies based on the version of the operating system. Symbols introduced in previous versions of iOS, iPadOS, iOS, tvOS, and watchOS are also available in macOS, and vice-versa.

Each set, or release, is named after the operating system that introduced the symbols, including the version number. For example, the first set of symbols, including the extension against using symbols, is all images in macOS 11 and iOS 14 is named "Cyclades 1.1". For a list of the available sets, see the Human Interface Guidelines, and download the latest version of the SF Symbols app.

Rendering modes

SF Symbols provides four rendering modes — monochrome, hierarchical, palette, and multicolor. Some symbols look better in one rendering mode versus another. For example, you might want to use a multicolor rendering mode for a symbol that represents a file type, but you might prefer a palette rendering mode for a system-defined symbol that represents a file type, because palette rendering mode enables you to specify a custom color for each layer, ensuring a visual hierarchy that good depths the symbol.

To learn more about supplying rendering modes in custom symbols, see Custom symbols.

SF Symbols supports the following rendering modes:

Monochrome — Applies one color to all layers in a symbol. Within a layer, the system applies a lighter shade of the specified color to layers that are farther from the viewer.

Hierarchical — Applies one color to all layers in a symbol, varying the color's opacity according to each layer's hierarchical level.

Palette — Applies two or more colors to a symbol, using one color per layer. Specifying a palette rendering mode for a symbol that defines three layers and only two colors means the secondary and tertiary layers use the same color.

Multicolor — Applies intrinsic colors to some symbols to enhance meaning. For example, a symbol representing a file type might use a representative of meaning the physical document, whereas the "Cloud" + Cloud symbol uses red to signal data loss. Some multicolor symbols include layers that use a specified color.

Regardless of rendering mode, using system-provided colors ensures that symbols automatically adjust to accessibility preferences and appearances (Apple Mail Marketing and Dark Mode). For developer guidance, see Applying rendering modes.

Symbols that support hierarchical rendering are clearly combined. Depending on the focus the size of a symbol and its surrounding elements, the system may use a different rendering mode. For example, a symbol that defines three layers and two colors, the system uses the automatically setting to get a symbol's preferred rendering mode, but if the symbol is small, the system uses the hierarchical rendering mode because using multi-layer colors is difficult.

Gradients

In SF Symbols 2 and later, gradient rendering generates a smooth gradient from the specified color, automatically adjusting the gradient's position and starting location for both system and custom symbols and for custom symbols. Gradients render for symbols of any size, but look best at large sizes.

Symbols 2.0

Variable color

Many variable colors, you can represent a characteristic that can change over time, such as the strength of a signal, the volume of a sound, or a percentage. To visually communicate such a change, variable color applies color to layers in a symbol that are in a state of being added or removed. For example, you could use variable color with the symbol "Wifi".

For example, you could use variable color with the symbol "Wifi". Wifi. Depending on the current value, the system applies a color to layers in the symbol that correspond to the current value. For example, if the current value is 0, the system does not apply color to the layers in the symbol. If the current value is 1, the system applies color to the layers in the symbol. Variable color supports values from 0 to 1, inclusive. Some symbols ship with variable color information that specifies defines based on the number of symbols elements you want to represent.

Sometimes, it can make sense for some of a symbol's layers to opt out of the variable color. For example, the "Wifi" symbol's layer that shows the outside arcs. Wifi. Because the arcs correspond to a specific value, the variable color indicates a greater doesn't change as the signal level changes. To ensure that the arcs don't change, you can specify that the layer is **not variable**

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